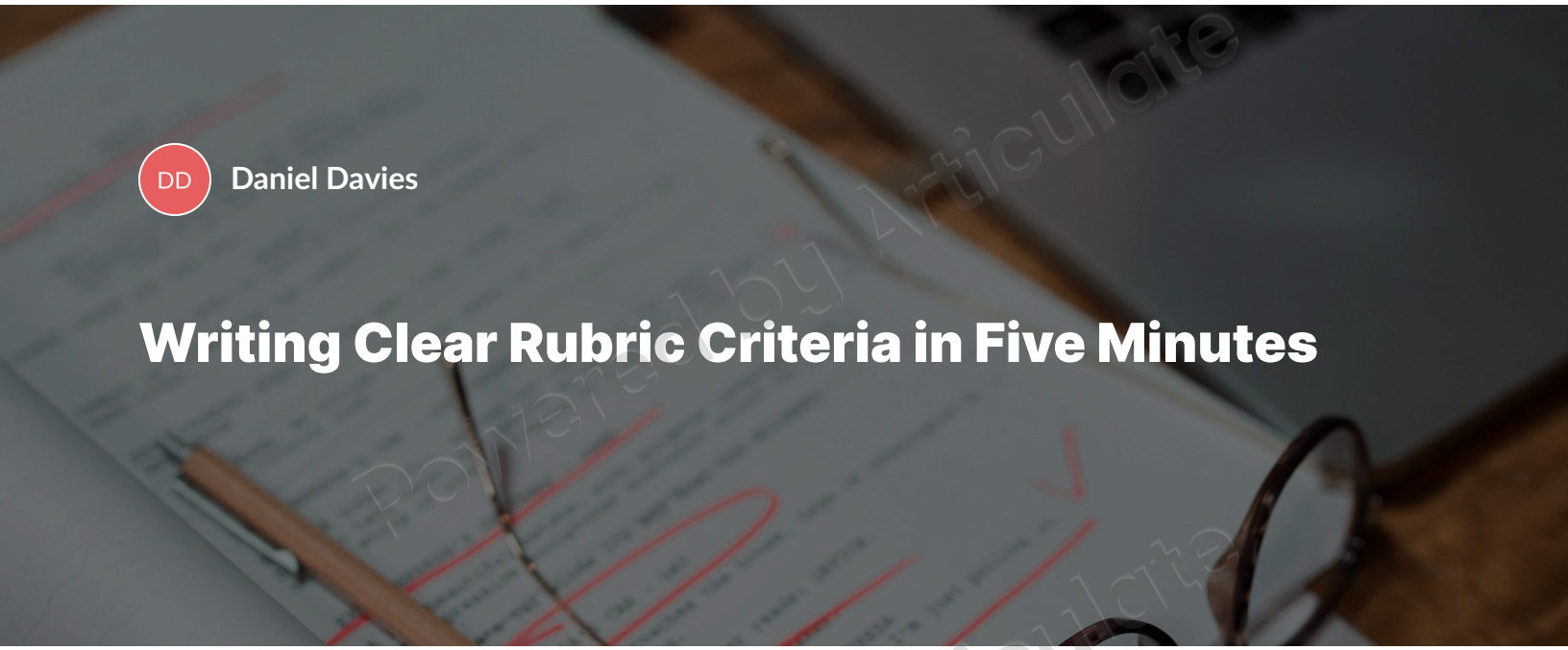


DD Daniel Davies

Writing Clear Rubric Criteria in Five Minutes

A short staff activity on writing criteria that a colleague, or a student, can actually use

Writing clear rubric criteria

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A rubric helps only if a colleague, or a student, can tell one level from the next.

Two parts, and one test

Brookhart (2018) describes a true rubric as having two parts: criteria (what to look for in the work) and performance-level descriptions (what those criteria look like at different levels of quality). That combination is what separates a rubric from a checklist or a rating scale.

A checklist only asks whether something is present. A rating scale asks you to choose a number or a label, such as "excellent" to "poor," without describing the work. Those tools can have a place, but they do not, on their own, show a student what better work looks like.

The criteria are the key. Brookhart (2018) argues that appropriate criteria should fit the purpose of the assessment, and that they should be substantive. If a criterion only counts features, such as "has five paragraphs," students can meet it without attending to quality. If the criterion describes quality, such as "states a clear and justified recommendation," attention to quality becomes part of the work.

All of the example lines in this activity are **generic teaching examples**. They are not from a real module.

Weak: "Excellent analysis."

Stronger: "Weighs at least one relevant risk or limitation against the recommendation, using evidence from the pack." The weak line is only a label. The stronger line describes the quality you want to see.

Weak: "Good use of sources."

Stronger: "Supports each main claim with a specific, relevant source that has been used accurately." "Good" does not tell a marker, or a student, what to look for.

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Weak: "Has four references."

Stronger: "Uses sources to justify the recommendation, not only to lengthen the reference list." Brookhart (2018) cautions that counting features can pull attention away from quality.

Weak: "Well written."

Stronger: "The briefing is organised so that the recommendation, the evidence, and any limitation can each be found quickly." The stronger line is still about communication, but it is observable.

Clear enough to mark

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Makes a recommendation and justifies it with evidence from the pack.

Identifies a limitation in the evidence, and how it affects the recommendation.

Uses professional English so a manager could act without rereading the briefing.

Too vague

Excellent work.

Includes three charts.

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Shows insight.

A Level 4 business briefing is meant to assess this outcome: "Students will be able to recommend a justified option, using evidence." Which criterion is the best fit for that purpose, following Brookhart (2018)?

- Has five paragraphs and four references.
- Makes a clear recommendation and justifies it with relevant evidence, including at least one limitation in that evidence.
- Excellent, very good, good, or poor.
- Shows enthusiasm for the subject.

SUBMIT

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If two colleagues cannot tell one level from the next, rewrite the line before you use it with students.

One next step, and a source

Take one criterion from a rubric you already use. Ask:

1. Does this line fit the outcome I am actually marking?

2. Does it describe quality, or does it only count features or say "excellent"?

3. Could a colleague, or a student, tell this level from the one below it?

Rewrite one line today. You do not need to rebuild the whole grid this afternoon.

Further reading

Brookhart, S. M. (2018). Appropriate criteria: Key to effective rubrics. Frontiers in Education, 3, Article 22. https://doi.org/10.3389/feduc.2018.00022

This source was opened and checked when the script was written. You do not need to read it in order to complete the activity.

This short activity was designed by Daniel P Davies, Associate Lecturer at Liverpool John Moores University.

Thank you for spending five minutes on this.

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